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The EN GARDE GAZETTE
THE ELITE FENCERS CLUB WEEKLY

It is better to deserve a rating than to have one.

TUESDAY EDITION
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Milinkovic Earns His A at Ultimate Cup

Maksim Milinkovic finished fifth of 83 in the Cadet Men's event at the Ultimate Cup in Hillsborough Township, N.J., on Oct. 31, and the result earned him an A rating, the highest rating USA Fencing awards. He had been a B since May.

The two-day regional at Iron Peak Sports & Events drew Elite FC fencers to Junior and Cadet events on both days. On Sunday, Nico Ng placed 10th of 87 in Junior Men.

Milinkovic is having a busy fall. Last month he was sixth at the FIE Cadet World Cup in San José, Costa Rica. His new rating reads A26: the letter, plus the year it was earned.

The club's biggest weekend ahead is the Cobra Challenge in Secaucus, Nov. 27–29, where 16 Elite FC fencers are entered.

The Youth Olympics, Explained

The Youth Olympic Games are an elite, multi-sport Olympics for athletes 17 and under, with an educational program built in. The fourth summer edition opened in Dakar, Senegal, on Oct. 31 and runs through Nov. 13. It's the first Olympic sporting event ever held in Africa, with about 2,700 athletes in 25 sports.

Fencing gets 84 places, 42 for young men and 42 for young women, with one individual event per weapon for each. No country may send more than one fencer per event, and there were no special qualifying tournaments: the federations set minimum standards, and national Olympic committees chose their athletes.

A fencer was part of the show from the start. Senegalese foil fencer Abdourahmane Marième Sy lit the cauldron at the opening ceremony.

Fencing runs Nov. 8–13 at the Dakar Expo Centre in Diamniadio. Women's épée is Nov. 10 and men's épée Nov. 11, each a single day from pools to the gold-medal bout. Past Youth Olympians include sprinter Noah Lyles and diver Tom Daley.

PHOTO FROM HISTORY

1996: Two Golds at the Start of an Olympic Era



Women's épée made its Olympic debut in Atlanta in 1996, and Laura Flessel won both available gold medals for France: individual and team. This later portrait shows her at a women's épée World Cup trophy presentation in Saint-Maur in 2013.

Laura Flessel won the first Olympic women's individual epee title in Atlanta in 1996, then added team gold with France. The individual final was an all-French contest: she defeated Valérie Barlois 15–12. Born in Guadeloupe, Flessel began fencing at seven and became known as "The Wasp." Her career stretched across five Olympics, with individual bronze in Sydney in 2000, individual silver and team bronze in Athens in 2004, and appearances in Beijing and London. She also won individual world titles in 1998 and 1999. This portrait was taken at the team trophy presentation of the 2013 Challenge international de Saint-Maur, a women's epee World Cup event.

Photo: © Marie-Lan Nguyen / Wikimedia Commons, "Laura Flessel-Colovic.jpg", CC BY 2.5 (creativecommons.org/licenses/by/2.5). Source: commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Laura_Flessel-Colovic.jpg. Cropped.

CLUB RESULTS

FENCER	EVENT	FINISH
Maksim Milinkovic	Ultimate Cup RJCC, Cadet Men (Oct. 31)	5th of 83 · earned A26
Nico Ng	Ultimate Cup RJCC, Junior Men (Nov. 1)	10th of 87
Christina Jiang	Fencers Club Youth Epee Cup, Y12 Mixed (Nov. 1)	3rd of 6

RATINGS EARNED

FENCER	RATING	WHERE
Maksim Milinkovic	A26 (from B26)	Ultimate Cup RJCC, Oct. 31

New Friday Class: Youth Intermediate

Elite FC is adding a Youth Intermediate group class on Fridays, 5:00–6:30 p.m., and is aiming to hold the first one this Friday, Nov. 6.

It's a step up from the beginner class. Beginners will keep training together, while more experienced youth fencers, the ones taking the sport more seriously and getting tournament-ready, get a class of their own.

The timing is handy, too: open bouting follows at 6:30 p.m., so fencers can stay afterward and keep sharpening their skills. The club will reach out to eligible fencers; questions go to the club.

BY THE BOOK

The 40-Millisecond Double

Why do both lights go on? In épée, when both fencers are hit and the scoring box registers both touches, it's a double touch, and each fencer gets a point (USA Fencing rule t.92).

The box decides. If the second hit lands within 40 milliseconds of the first (1/25 of a second), both lamps light. Past 50 milliseconds (1/20), only the first counts; the box is allowed some leeway in between. The World Fencing League keeps the idea: "If both hit within 40ms, both score."

NEARBY TOURNAMENTS — ELITE FC ENTRIES

NYFA YOUTH CUP #1 · Brooklyn, N.Y. · Sunday, Nov. 8

TIME	EVENT	ELITE FC
9:00 AM	Y10 Mixed	Bryce Cheng, Maximus Siu
9:00 AM	Y8 Mixed	Madeline Siu
12:30 PM	Y12 Men	Remy Ng
12:30 PM	Y12 Women	Christina Jiang
4:00 PM	Y14 Women	Mila Siu

PIZZA RYC/RJCC · New Haven, Conn. · Nov. 14–15

TIME	EVENT	ELITE FC
SATURDAY, NOV. 14		
8:00 AM	Y14 Women	Penny Young
1:00 PM	Junior Women	Amina Gore
SUNDAY, NOV. 15		
8:00 AM	Cadet Women	Amina Gore, Penny Young
12:00 PM	Y12 Women	Penny Young

MEDEO YOUTH CHALLENGE #5 · Bound Brook, N.J. · Sunday, Nov. 8

TIME	EVENT	ELITE FC
9:30 AM	Y12 Men	Samuel SarroWaite
9:30 AM	Y12 Women	Christina Jiang
11:30 AM	Y10 Mixed	Nora Li, Claire Widjaja
11:30 AM	Y14 Men	Owen Li
11:30 AM	Y14 Women	Mira Shukla

COBRA CHALLENGE SYC/RCC · Secaucus, N.J. · Nov. 27–29

EVENT	ELITE FC
FRIDAY, NOV. 27	
Y14 Men	Connor Anderson, Noah Gore, Kian Jaising, Remy Ng, Ash Shah-Mirani
Cadet Women	Amina Gore, Olivia Hayes, Stella Kuo, Lillian Liu, Mila Siu, Penny Young
Y10 Men	Bryce Cheng, Joshua Jeong
SATURDAY, NOV. 28	
Y12 Women	Christina Jiang, Stella Kuo, Mila Siu, Penny Young
Y12 Men	Kian Jaising, Joshua Jeong, Remy Ng
SUNDAY, NOV. 29	
Y14 Women	Stella Kuo, Mila Siu, Penny Young
Cadet Men	Connor Anderson, Nico Ng, Caden Wu

Cobra Challenge is at the Meadowlands Expo Center: 16 Elite FC fencers, 26 entries.

OVERHEARD ON REDDIT

Can the FIE Tell You Where Not to Fence?

The debate this fall on r/Fencing: the world federation's warning about the new World Fencing League set off a 50-comment argument.

What the FIE actually said. According to the South China Morning Post, a statement signed by FIE Secretary General Gulnora Saidova on Oct. 22 said the league is not an official competition, and none of its planned events is sanctioned. It pointed to rules that allow bans. (We couldn't find the full text posted publicly.) The rule, Article 1.2.6(b), bars federation members from events run by anyone "not recognised by the national federation of their country," unless that federation specially authorizes them.

What the WFL is. It's a made-for-TV team league started by U.S. Olympian Miles Chamley-Watson. Its one event so far, in Los Angeles in April, offered a $100,000 prize pool. In épée, a 45-second clock punishes passive fencing.

Opinion: it's overreach. Running your own championships is fine, but banning members from someone else's show isn't. And "event" is never defined.

Opinion: you signed up for it. Joining a federation means accepting its rules. The FIE is worried about rivals, not club tournaments.

What it means for club fencers. By the rule's own wording, USA Fencing tournaments and events run by recognized clubs are unaffected. One wrinkle: USA Fencing itself signed a partnership with the WFL in January, and it hasn't commented publicly.

Fact check: *Seven weeks before the warning, the FIE hosted Chamley-Watson in Lausanne for "positive discussions."*

EPEE ON SCREEN

DATES	EVENT
Nov. 5–8	Junior/Cadet World Cup, Manama, Bahrain
Nov. 8–13	Youth Olympic Games, Dakar, Senegal
Nov. 12–15	Senior World Cups: Berne (men), Wuxi (women) — FencingTV
Nov. 26–29	Junior/Cadet World Cup, Novi Sad, Serbia

From the FIE calendar; only the senior World Cups list a stream.

DEADLINES

DATE	WHAT CLOSES
Sat 11/7	Cobra Challenge: late entry closes
Sat 11/7	Medeo #5: preregistration closes
Wed 11/11	Junior Olympics: regular-fee deadline
Fri 1/8	N.J. high school: independent fencers' entries close

USA Fencing deadlines are 11:59 p.m. Pacific (2:59 a.m. Eastern the next day).

Winter Camp: Sign Up Now

Elite FC Winter Camp runs Dec. 27–31, 9:30 a.m. to 2 p.m., and it's open to all levels: footwork, technical and tactical drills, and games. Dec. 27 starts with a swag giveaway. K2 Fitness runs strength and conditioning on Dec. 28 and 30. On Dec. 29, a professional instructor leads yoga and breath control for competition, and lunch is served. Crepes on Dec. 31 celebrate the end of camp and 2026. Call it a tune-up for the second half of the season, or a good excuse to escape visiting relatives for a few hours. If you're going, let the club know as soon as possible for a headcount; contact the club for price and sign-up.